

Leave them games alone

I wouldn't normally touch a politically-charged topic with a ten-foot barge pole, because I'd rather not play in the muck and get my hands dirty. However, thanks to Electronics Arts (EA), the UK defense secretary and an upcoming game called Medal of Honor, a lot of us find ourselves having to form an opinion on the subject. I figured I'd share mine with you.

For those who don't even know what I'm talking about, Medal of Honor has been in the news recently because of one simple fact – the game allows you to choose sides in the Afghan war... so basically, you can choose to play as the Taliban and fight against the western soldiers.

EA, to its credit, has done a lot of research for this game, and even hired ex-special forces members to ensure that there's a lot more "reality" to the gameplay and the visuals. However, the company has come under a lot of flak for the aforementioned feature, especially from UK Defence Secretary, Liam Fox, who is urging British game retailers to ban the game on UK shores, saying that it's just shameful and un-British.

Now I'm not saying EA is completely innocent here, and maybe they really should have avoided choosing an ongoing war as the setting, and instead, based their game in WWII or Vietnam or the future, like every other good little game publishing company. But those old wars aren't controversial, and don't get you any publicity, do they?

EA's take on the whole matter is that if someone's a cop, then someone else has to play the robber. They're saying that setting the game in Afghanistan was an "artistic choice", but perhaps it was more of a marketing decision to capitalise on a sensitive topic. EA's not the only one of course; so many books and movies have been based on the same topic in the last few years that it's hard to keep count.

What I'd like to know is how come no one cribs about a little game called Counter-Strike (CS). With so many countries suffering terrorist attacks, why is no one is up in arms to ban a game that expects one team to play as terrorists and blow up a bomb? Where are all the politicians that claim to be acting in the interests of the grieving family members of 9/11, or our

very own 26/11? Is there no real publicity to be gained from boycotting a 11-year old game, even if millions still play it? How come it's OK for similar shoot-em-up games to be used as a recruitment tool, as in the case of the game America's Army?

What's the message we're sending to the world here? It's OK to shoot, blow-up, kill, maim and massacre humans in a game, so long as it's bad guys you're doing all that to? Bad guys are defined by the country you live in and the politics you follow, but in games, we have no hatred for the bad guys. They're just obstacles to overcome in order to beat the game. Why can't we just leave well-enough alone?

IRS 2010 report

I also wanted to share some important news with you. The latest Indian Readership Survey (IRS) 2010 results are out. IRS is the largest and most comprehensive independent survey for all print publications in India. As per the latest report, amongst the top 20 English magazines published in India, Digit is the fastest growing. Digit is also amongst the top 10 monthly English magazines in India, and no other technology magazine features amongst the top 20.

This is a very proud achievement for every member of Team Digit. We promise to steadily improve every aspect of this magazine, and find ways to be even more beneficial to the Digit community. With your continued support, we're confident of doing even better in the months and years to come. Please keep the suggestions and feedback flowing in, and help us reach out to even more people than before by recommending your favourite magazine to your friends. Team Digit would like to sincerely thank each and every one of you for being the greatest set of readers that other magazines can only dream of having... **d**



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor

"With so many countries suffering terrorist attacks, why is no one is up in arms to ban a game that expects one team to play as terrorists and blow up a bomb?"

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Shawn Smith'.

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